

The Yellow Wallpaper

“The Yellow Wallpaper” is a short story by Charlotte Perkins Gilman, first published in January 1892. A landmark of feminist Gothic fiction, it follows a woman undergoing a “rest cure” whose enforced isolation and confinement drive her toward psychological collapse.

Key facts

- **Author:** Charlotte Perkins Gilman
- **First publication:** January 1892 (in *The New England Magazine*)
- **Genre:** Gothic fiction, psychological horror, feminist literature
- **Setting:** A rented country mansion, likely late 19th-century America
- **Narrative style:** First-person journal entries, unreliable narrator

Plot and structure

Presented as a series of secret journal entries, the story follows an unnamed woman taken to a secluded house by her physician husband, John, after childbirth and emotional distress. Forbidden to work or write, she becomes fixated on the room’s disturbing yellow wallpaper, gradually imagining a trapped woman moving behind its patterns until her obsession culminates in a complete break from reality.

Themes and interpretation

Gilman critiques the medical and social treatment of women by showing how paternalism, enforced passivity, and the denial of autonomy can become psychologically destructive. The wallpaper functions as both a symbol of domestic imprisonment and a projection of the narrator’s own fractured identity, making the story a powerful study of gender, power, and mental health.

Style and influence

With its intimate voice, tightening atmosphere, and blend of realism and horror, “The Yellow Wallpaper” remains one of the most widely studied short stories in American literature. Its psychological depth and feminist force helped establish it as a foundational text in discussions of women’s writing, Gothic fiction, and the literature of mental illness.